

Congratulations, Columbia Class of 2026.

Thank you, President Shipman, and thank you to the Board of Trustees for this honor. When I got the call to do this, I was running to class. I still picked up, and a woman asked me to confirm my name. I said it, and then I paused.

As an immigrant, you learn to live inside pauses.

The pause before your next check-in. The pause before your next hearing date. The pause before you refresh a portal, open an envelope, or answer an unknown number while running to class, because you have learned that a single line of text can split your life into a before and an after. Even when you are doing everything right, you still find yourself holding your breath.

We are told to “do it the right way,” especially as students. So we do. We study. We meet deadlines. We show up to office hours. We take notes like our futures depend on them, because sometimes they do. We work so hard we learn to breathe in fragments. And if you have ever lived under a system that can erase you with a missed appointment, you begin to understand something else: even those of us who follow every rule sometimes wonder whether the rules were built with us in mind. You can do everything asked of you and still feel like you’re sprinting on a track that keeps moving.

That's what makes this day so extraordinary.

Because we are here anyway.

We are here because something inside us refused to accept that our lives would be limited to fear, or to what other people decided was "possible." We are here because each of us has been running our own race. Some of you ran toward research. Some ran toward art. Some ran toward psychology, toward law, toward engineering, toward the chance to build something that lasts. Some of you ran away from grief, or scarcity, or expectations that felt too small for who you were becoming. And many of you did what students have always done at Columbia: you ran toward the hardest questions, because you believed the answers mattered.

For some people, running is a choice. A marathon you sign up for. A workout. A metaphor. For others, running is not a metaphor. It is survival. It is the quiet urgency of knowing you cannot miss the appointment, cannot miss the deadline, cannot miss the email, cannot miss the moment when someone decides whether you get to stay in the race.

And as immigrants, we keep running, hoping one day we reach the finish line, or at least a place where we can finally breathe.

The truth is, the finish line does exist. But it does not always look like a ribbon you break through. Sometimes it looks like an email that says "approved." Sometimes it looks like a professor who says "I believe in you." Sometimes it looks like a library card. Sometimes it looks like a good friend! So break the ICE, speak to the right people, form a connection, grab a drink! (but please hold the ICE)

Opportunity is a door that opens because someone decides to see you. Sometimes it is a friend's

mother who looks past your circumstances and recognizes your potential. Sometimes it is someone late at night. who answers a call, reads a message, invites you to their place, or stays on the line long enough for your life to turn back toward safety. Sometimes it is an admissions officer who opens your file, reads your words, and chooses to believe that you belong here right now. And most of the time, opportunity does not announce itself with fireworks. It arrives quietly, in the form of one person taking a chance.

The point is not to romanticize luck. The point is to honor it by becoming the kind of person who passes it on.

So as you step into what comes next, remember this: the world will tell you to be practical. Be practical. The world will tell you to be ambitious. Be ambitious. But do not become so busy building your own life that you forget how many lives are built by a single moment of generosity.

Make room. Hold the door. Write the email. Make the introduction. Speak up when someone is being erased. Refuse to laugh at the cruel joke. Choose the hard kindness. Because at some point, whether you realize it or not, you will become the person standing between someone else and their finish line.

And if you ever doubt whether your choices matter, look around.

Look at the person beside you. Look at the faculty who saw something in you before you fully saw it in yourself. Look at the friend who reminded you to eat. The mentor who wrote the recommendation letter. The stranger who offered directions. None of those moments were inevitable. They were choices. They were opportunity in motion.

Class of 2026, I want you to leave here with confidence, but also with a kind of humility that

keeps you human. Keep learning. Keep questioning. Keep building. But do not surrender your heart to cynicism. Do not confuse being jaded with being wise. And when you find yourself living inside a pause, do not let it become paralysis. Let it become a promise.

A promise to keep going. A promise to stay honest. A promise to build a future big enough to include people who have been told they do not belong.

Because the finish line should not exist only for people running for office. It should exist for people running to class. It should exist for people running a double shift. It should exist for people running from war, from persecution, from hunger, from silence, from the fear that no one will ever see them. It should exist for people chasing the American dream. Congratulations class of 2026!